

HEMANT CHAWLA



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of militant groups which have come up since 1989 is not easy. And I personally feel that dispute resolution is the only permanent solution.

The new phenomenon of terrorism and extremism has erupted in your society and in Pakistan's society. You need to address the alienation and the frustration of the minorities in general and the Muslims in particular. In India as a result of some prejudices, unequal opportunities, maybe some atrocities, are leading to extremism within the Muslim youth. Don't think that I am not cognisant about what is happening in Pakistan's society. We face challenges from four facets of terrorism and extremism. We face the challenge of terrorism from Al Qaeda; we face the challenge of terrorism from militant Taliban; we face the challenge of extremism of the Talibanisation of the tribal districts of the Frontier Province; and we

face the challenge of extremism in our society.

But I want to emphasise, if you kill terrorists, whenever anything happens, whether it is Mumbai, Lahore or anywhere, you have plucked leaves of a tree. The leaves will grow again, maybe in greater numbers. If you are able to cut off any terrorist organisation, you have chopped of one branch of that tree; the tree will continue to grow. You have to get to the root of that tree, uproot that tree, then only will you end terrorism and extremism and that is the root that I always keep talking about. My belief has always been that terrorism is born from the womb of festering political disputes which need to be resolved.

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DISCUSSION

day one, the ISI and Pakistan Government were blamed. Now, should we say the same thing for Lahore too? No we must not say that. We need to be sober and calculative; we need to give more considered views. But yes, the Pakistan Government should cooperate because this terrorist attack has taken place and anyone who has done it needs to be punished.

Q. Do you agree that Mumbai attacks were planned from Pakistan?

A. I can't say because I am not privy to the evidence you sent to Pakistan.

Q. Many of us in India believe that the present rapprochement feelers are a tactical ploy on part of Pakistan and not a strategic change of heart?

A. Every country has its national interest that it pursues and so does India. Let me assure you, whether you believe it or not, that the ISI and the army are totally on

board about having peace with India. After all, the ISI has a role to play just like your RAW has a role to play—to protect the interests of the nation. Please don't think that we are having a double-faced game going on, that we are bluffing you while trying to talk peace, and the ISI and the army do not want peace. This theory is wrong.

Q. Are there training camps for the terrorists in Pakistan?

A. This is a time for frank talk. You try to inflict damage on us and we are not sitting idle, we try to do damage to you. That is the reality of Pakistan and India. RAW does exactly what ISI does. Let us stop the confrontation between ISI and RAW.

Q. If Pakistan deports Dawood Ibrahim there can be a sea change in relations. Why don't you do that?

A. I agree with you that we need to banish each other's terrorists. It can be

done as I said when both ISI and RAW drop their confrontationalist attitude. Now Dawood is an element of the same relationship. Let me say with full understanding that even if Dawood is handed over the relationship between India and Pakistan will not improve. We will try this but if we fail, you hand him back to us.

Q. But why is it that despite Pakistan's assurances not to allow its territory to be used for terrorist acts, Mumbai happens?

A. I think we are again revolving around on the same issue of our hatred of each other. The past has been bad, but the blame is on both sides. So, therefore, bury the past and let us start afresh.

Q. What specific confidence building measures can work between us?

A. We have to see from a strategic angle what needs to be done to bring Pakistan and India closer. We need to address the Kashmir dispute.

You want to talk of Dawood Ibrahim—one man—but you don't want to talk about Kashmir. You don't want to talk about why Jaish-e-Mohammad and Lashkar-e-Toiba came into being. They came into being because of their sympathy with the Muslims of India in general, and Kashmir in particular.

Q. Would you want to join one of the political parties or do you think you should wait till the army clears up the mess?

A. I am relaxing and I have played my innings. I would like to see Pakistan move forward and therein I see concerns in how we deal with the problems in Pakistan—the economic problems, political problems, terrorism, extremism, law and order problems. I have no intention of joining politics.

Q. So, are you back in the pavilion? Will you be a commentator or the third umpire.

A. I would like to be third umpire between India and Pakistan.

Q. General you talked about the problems faced by Indian Muslims, but you should concentrate on Muslims in Pakistan. Why are you trying to alienate Indian Muslims by your remarks?

A. I am not playing any politics for Pakistan here. I was trying to make a frank comment and you should have the courage to hear it, but if you say that the condition of Indian Muslims is good, then I wish you luck.

Q. What is it like to live in Pakistan but not be in charge?

A. I think it is very good. I think the most difficult thing for a leader, when you say you are in charge, is to take decisions. So, while I was facing this difficulty over eight years, now I read them in newspapers and don't have to take any decisions, which others have to do now.